

St Basil's Cathedral

Built in 1555–61 on Moscow's main marketplace by the order of Ivan IV the Terrible (1530–84), the Cathedral of Vasily the Blessed – St Basil – was a symbol of the might of Russia and its tsars, commemorating Russian victory over the Mongols at Kazan in 1552. The architect is not known, though the names Barma and Posnik are cited. The colourful variegated onion domes have become a symbol of Moscow, and of Russia as a whole, though they are in fact 17th-century replacements for the original helmet-shaped domes

Although the building looks asymmetrical from the outside, the interior follows a formally structured plan, with the main church in the centre and eight chapels arranged evenly around it. Each side chapel has its own distinctive tower, surmounted by a dome, and is connected to the others by narrow winding passages. While the style of the church appears unique, some elements resemble those in the wooden churches built in northern Russia in previous eras.

